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HERE'S THE TOP-GROSSING FILM FOR EACH YEAR FROM 1977 TO 2025

How many of these year-end box-office champs have you seen?

By **Paul Grein**

12/29/2025



From left: Black Panther, Titanic, Spider-Man, Grease, Top Gun

ILLUSTRATION BY JULIETTE TOMA



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Most *Billboard* readers have at least a rough idea of the top albums and songs of each year but may be less familiar with the top box-office hits from each year.

Fortunately, [boxofficemojo.com](https://www.boxofficemojo.com) has **that information**

([https://www.boxofficemojo.com/year/?](https://www.boxofficemojo.com/year/?ref=bo_nb_hm_secondarytab)

ref=bo_nb_hm_secondarytab) for each year dating back to 1977.

So what do we learn scrolling through the list of top-grossing films for each year since Jimmy Carter became president and Elvis Presley died? One thing that comes across loud and clear is the degree to which sequels and franchises have come to dominate the marketplace. Just five of the year-end box-office champs were films that were *not* part of franchises (or did not spark a franchise or a reboot of some kind). Those five films that stand alone are *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*, *Who Framed Roger Rabbit*, *Ghost*, *Titanic* and *Barbie*.

Star Wars is the top franchise on this recap, with six installments that have been the year's top-grossing film. *Batman* is runner-up, with four installments that finished first for the year. *Spider-Man* is third, with three installments that yielded the year's top box-office hit.

James Cameron and George Lucas are tied as the only directors who each directed three films that took the year-end crown. Tim Burton, Sam Raimi, Tony Scott, Steven Spielberg, Andrew Stanton and Robert Zemeckis are tied for second place, each having directed two year-end champs.

John Williams (<https://www.billboard.com/artist/john-williams/>) is

far and away the top film scorer. The legendary composer scored 10 films that took the year-end box-office crown. **Danny Elfman**,

(<https://www.billboard.com/artist/danny-elfman/>) **Alan Silvestri**

([https://www.billboard.com/culture/tv-film/alan-silvestri-](https://www.billboard.com/culture/tv-film/alan-silvestri-composer-interview-8541590/)

composer-interview-8541590/) and **Hans Zimmer**

(<https://www.billboard.com/artist/hans-zimmer/>) have each scored films that finished first four times.

Let's scroll back through the films that had the most success at the domestic box office (that's the U.S. and Canada) in each calendar year since 1977, when *Annie* debuted on Broadway, *Laverne & Shirley* was the top TV show and Fleetwood Mac's *Rumours* dominated the *Billboard* 200.

1977: *Star Wars*



Star Wars: A New Hope, 1977.
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Stars: Mark Hamill, Harrison Ford, Carrie Fisher, Peter Cushing, Alec Guinness

Director: George Lucas

Music: John Williams

Release date: May 25

Domestic grosses that year: \$196 million

Academy Awards: 10 nods, including best picture and directing. Six wins, including best original score, plus a special achievement award to Benjamin Burt Jr. “for the creation of the alien, creature and robot voices featured in *Star Wars*.”

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 2 (three weeks)

Notes: Williams won three Grammys and an Oscar for his work on the film. The double-disc soundtrack received a Grammy nomination for album of the year but lost to Fleetwood Mac's *Rumours* (which was also the album that kept it out of the No. 1 spot). Williams' recording of the main title theme reached No. 10 on the Hot 100. A disco cover version by Meco hit No. 1.

1978: *Grease*

(/)

Stars: John Travolta, Olivia Newton-John, Stockard Channing, Jeff Conaway, Didi Conn

Director: Randal Kleiser

Music: Michael Gibson

Release date: June 16

Domestic grosses that year: \$160 million

Academy Awards: One nod for "Hopelessly Devoted to You" as best original song. John Farrar wrote Newton-John's showcase ballad.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (12 weeks)

Notes: *Grease* is the only musical to take the year-end box-office crown. Four singles from the album made the top five on the Hot 100. Two made No. 1 – Travolta & Newton-John's "You're the One That I Want" and Frankie Valli's "Grease." The double-disc soundtrack received a Grammy nod for album of the year, but lost to the Bee Gees-led *Saturday Night Fever* soundtrack.

1979: *Superman*

(/)

Stars: Christopher Reeve. Margot Kidder. Marlon Brando. Gene Hackman. Ned

Beatty

Director: Richard Donner

Music: John Williams

Release date: Dec. 15, 1978

Domestic grosses that year: \$93 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (film editing, original score, sound). The film also won a special achievement award (visual effects).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 44

Notes: *Superman* was the No. 9 box-office hit of 1978, its year of release, and still went on to gross more than any other film in 1979. The double-disc soundtrack included a minor Hot 100 hit, London Symphony Orchestra’s “Theme From Superman (Main Title),” and a pretty ballad, “Can You Read My Mind,” that became a mid-chart Hot 100 hit for Maureen McGovern.

1980: *The Empire Strikes Back* (L)

Stars: Mark Hamill, Harrison Ford, Carrie Fisher, Billy Dee Williams, Alec Guinness

Director: Irvin Kershner

Music: John Williams

Release date: May 21

Domestic grosses that year: \$203 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (art direction, original score, sound). One win – sound – plus a special achievement award for visual effects.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 4

Notes: *The Empire Strikes Back* was the second film in the *Star Wars* franchise. The era of franchises and sequels was officially upon us. For risk-averse movie studios, it sure beat coming up with fresh ideas. And the public didn’t seem to mind: *The Empire Strikes Back* was the first film to gross more than \$200 million in a calendar year. The double-disc soundtrack was a hit. With *Empire* coming on the heels of *Superman*, Williams became the first composer to score films that were back-to-back year-end box-office champs.

1981: *Superman II*

(D)

Stars: Christopher Reeve, Margot Kidder, Gene Hackman, Jackie Cooper, Ned Beatty

Director: Richard Lester

Music: Ken Thorne

Release date: June 19

Domestic grosses that year: \$108 million

Academy Awards: Not a single nomination.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 133

Notes: Composer Ken Thorne took over the franchise from the very busy John Williams.

1982: *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*

(L)



E.T., 1982

UNIVERSAL PICTURES/ COURTESY: EVERETT COLLECTION

Stars: Dee Wallace, Henry Thomas, Peter Coyote, Robert MacNaughton, Drew Barrymore

Director: Steven Spielberg

Music: John Williams

Release date: June 11

Domestic grosses that year: \$315 million

Academy Awards: Nine nods, including best picture and best directing. Four wins including best original score.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 37

Notes: *E.T.* was the first film to gross more than \$300 million in a calendar year. Michael Jackson and Neil Diamond also benefited from the film's success. Jackson narrated an *E.T.* storybook album that won a Grammy on the same night as his *Thriller* sweep. This enabled him to set a new record for most Grammys won in one night – eight. (Without the *E.T.* storybook album, Jackson would have merely tied Paul Simon's old record of seven wins in one night.)

Diamond scored a top five hit on the Hot 100 with the album *E.T. Imagined*

Diamond scored a top five hit on the Hot 100 with the warm, *E.T.*-inspired “Heartlight.”

1983: *Return of the Jedi***(L)**

Stars: Mark Hamill, Harrison Ford, Carrie Fisher, Billy Dee Williams, Anthony Daniels

Director: Richard Marquand

Music: John Williams

Release date: May 25

Domestic grosses that year: \$247 million

Academy Awards: Four nods including best original score. No wins, but the film received a special achievement award for visual effects.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 20

Notes: This was the third film in the *Star Wars* franchise. All three became the year’s top-grossing hit. Unlike the first two *Stars Wars* films, the *Jedi* soundtrack was just a single-disc release. With *Jedi* coming a year after *E.T.*, Williams scored films that were back-to-back year-end box-office champs for the second time.

1984: *Ghostbusters***(L)**

Stars: Bill Murray, Dan Aykroyd, Sigourney Weaver, Harold Ramis, Rick Moranis

Director: Ivan Reitman

Music: Elmer Bernstein

Release date: June 8

Domestic grosses that year: \$221 million

Academy Awards: Two nods – best visual effects and best original song for Ray Parker Jr.’s Hot 100-topping title song.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 6

Notes: Ray Parker Jr.’s “Ghostbusters” topped the Hot 100 for three weeks. It was letter-perfect for the film, which is the primary goal of any film song.

1985: *Back to the Future*

(/)

Stars: Michael J. Fox, Christopher Lloyd, Lea Thompson, Crispin Glover, Thomas F. Wilson

Director: Robert Zemeckis

Music: Alan Silvestri

Release date: July 3

Domestic grosses that year: \$191 million

Academy Awards: Four nods including best original song for Huey Lewis & the News’ Hot 100-topping “The Power of Love.” One win – sound effects editing.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 12

Notes: In addition to starring in the year's top box-office hit, Fox starred in the sitcom *Family Ties*, which was second only to *The Cosby Show* as the top-rated TV series for both the 1985-86 and 1986-87 seasons. In addition to its Oscar nod, Huey Lewis & the News' "The Power of Love" topped the Hot 100 for two weeks and received a Grammy nod for record of the year. It was another song that was perfect for its film.

1986: *Top Gun* (L)

Stars: Tom Cruise, Kelly McGillis, Val Kilmer, Anthony Edwards, Tom Skerritt

Director: Tony Scott

Music: Harold Faltermeyer

Release date: May 16

Domestic grosses that year: \$177 million

Academy Awards: Four nods. One win – best original song for Berlin's Hot 100-topping "Take My Breath Away"

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (five weeks)

Notes: Two songs from the soundtrack became top five hits on the Hot 100 – Berlin's "Take My Breath Away" (which hit No. 1) and Kenny Loggins' "Danger Zone" (No. 2). A third song from the album, Loverboy's "Heaven in Your Eyes," reached No. 12.

1987: *Beverly Hills Cop II* (L)

Stars: Eddie Murphy, Judge Reinhold, Brigitte Nielsen, Ronny Cox, John Ashton

Director: Tony Scott

Music: Harold Faltermeyer

Release date: May 20

Domestic grosses that year: \$154 million

Academy Awards: One nod – best original song for Bob Seger’s Hot 100-topping “Shakedown.”

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 8

Notes: Murphy became the first Black actor to be the top-billed star of the year’s top box-office hit. With this film coming on the heels of *Top Gun*, Scott became the only person to direct films that were the year’s top box-office champs two years running. In addition, Faltermeyer supervised the music on the year’s box-office champ two years running. The first *Beverly Hills Cop* was the No. 2 box-office hit of 1985. Three songs from *Cop II* made the top 10 on the Hot 100 – Bob Seger’s “Shakedown” (the only No. 1 of his long career), George Michael’s “I Want Your Sex” (No. 2) and The Jets’ “Cross My Broken Heart” (No. 7).

1988: *Who Framed Roger Rabbit*

(L)

Stars: Bob Hoskins, Christopher Lloyd, Charles Fleischer, Stubby Kaye, Joanna Cassidy

Director: Robert Zemeckis

Music: Alan Silvestri

Release date: June 24

Domestic grosses that year: \$156 million

Academy Awards: Six nods. Three wins (film editing, sound effects editing, visual effects), plus a special achievement award to Richard Williams for the film’s animation direction.

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: didn’t chart

Notes: This film blended live action and animation. Disney executives fretted that the film was too risqué but Zemeckis’ contract gave him final cut and he refused to make the changes the studio sought. Roy E. Disney, head of Feature Animation, and studio chief Jeffrey Katzenberg had an inspired solution. They released the film under the studio’s adult-focused Touchstone Pictures banner instead of the flagship Walt Disney Pictures banner. (And that’s why Hollywood execs make the big bucks.) This was the second year-end champ for both director Zemeckis and composer Silvestri, following their 1985 collab, *Back to the Future*.

1989: *Batman*

(/)

Batman, 1989.
WARNER BROTHERS/COURTESY EVERETT COLLECTION

Stars: Michael Keaton, Jack Nicholson, Kim Basinger, Robert Wuhl, Pat Hingle

Director: Tim Burton

Music: Danny Elfman

Release date: June 23

Domestic grosses that year: \$251 million

Academy Awards: One nod and one win (art direction).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (six weeks)

Notes: While Elfman’s score soundtrack peaked at a respectable No. 30 on the Billboard 200, Prince’s collection of “songs from and inspired by” *Batman* spent six weeks at No. 1. This set the pattern for future releases — a score soundtrack for collectors and soundtrack enthusiasts and a pop compilation soundtrack for the masses. One of Prince’s songs, “Batdance,” topped the Hot 100. Two others, “Partyman” and “The Arms of Orion” (with Sheena Easton), made the top 40.

1990: *Ghost*

(1)

Stars: Patrick Swayze, Demi Moore, Whoopi Goldberg, Tony Goldwyn

Director: Jerry Zucker

Music: Maurice Jarre

Release date: July 13

Domestic grosses that year: \$205 million

Academy Awards: Five nods including best picture and best original score.
Two wins – Whoopi Goldberg for best supporting actress and Bruce Joel Rubin

for his original screenplay.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 8

Notes: The soundtrack included The Righteous Brothers' 1965 classic "Unchained Melody," which became a hit all over again after soundtracking the film's sensuous pottery-wheel scene. The song was already a decade old when The Righteous Brothers cut it in 1965. It was introduced in the 1955 film *Unchained*, and even got an Oscar nod that year for best original song. It was a smash hit that year for orchestra leader Les Baxter.

1991: *Terminator 2: Judgment Day*

(D)

Stars: Arnold Schwarzenegger, Linda Hamilton, Robert Patrick

Director: James Cameron

Music: Brad Fiedel

Release date: July 3

Domestic grosses that year: \$205 million

Academy Awards: Six nods. Four wins – makeup, sound, sound effects editing and visual effects.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 70

Notes: This was the second film in the franchise. The first, *The Terminator*, was the No. 21 box-office hit of 1984.

1992: *Batman Returns*

(A)

Stars: Michael Keaton, Michelle Pfeiffer, Danny DeVito, Christopher Walken, Michael Gough

Director: Tim Burton

Music: Danny Elfman

Release date: June 19

Domestic grosses that year: \$163 million

Academy Awards: Two nods (makeup and visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 61

Notes: Burton and Elfman were the first director and composer to collaborate on two films from the same franchise that were each the No. 1 box-office champ of the year. George Lucas and John Williams equaled the feat in 1999 (and surpassed it in 2005). Andrew Stanton and Thomas Newman equaled the feat in 2016.

1993: *Jurassic Park*

A.D.

Stars: Sam Neill, Laura Dern, Jeff Goldblum, Richard Attenborough, Wayne Knight

Director: Steven Spielberg

Music: John Williams

Release date: June 11

Domestic grosses that year: \$339 million

Academy Awards: Three nods and three wins (sound, sound effects editing, visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No 36

Notes: This film grossed more in a calendar year than any film up to that point. Spielberg and Williams had previously collaborated on *E.T.*, the 1982 box-office champ.

1994: *The Lion King* (D)



The Lion King, 1994.
WALT DISNEY CO./COURTESY EVERETT COLLECTION

Stars: (voice cast) Jonathan Taylor Thomas, Jeremy Irons, James Earl Jones, Matthew Broderick

Director: Roger Allers, Rob Minkoff

Music: Hans Zimmer

Release date: June 15

Domestic grosses that year: \$296 million

Academy Awards: Four nods. Two wins – best original song and best original score.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (10 weeks)

Notes: This was the first wholly animated film to emerge as the year's top box-office hit. It was also the first film with two credited directors to become the year's box-office champ. *The Lion King* was the second film (following *Beauty and the Beast*) to spawn three Oscar nominees for best original song – “Can You Feel the Love Tonight,” “Circle of Life” and “Hakuna Matata.” Elton John and Tim Rice wrote all three songs. “Can You Feel the Love Tonight” won.

1995: *Batman Forever*

(D)

Stars: Val Kilmer, Tommy Lee Jones, Jim Carrey, Nicole Kidman, Chris O'Donnell

Director: Joel Schumacher

Music: Elliot Goldenthal

Release date: June 16

Domestic grosses that year: \$184 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (cinematography, sound, sound effects editing)

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 5

Notes: This was the third film in the franchise. All three wound up as the year's top box-office hit. *Batman* was the first franchise since *Star Wars* to achieve that feat. (No subsequent franchise has equaled the feat.) The soundtrack featured Seal's elegant “Kiss From a Rose,” which topped the Hot 100 and won

Grammys for record and song of the year. It also featured U2's "Hold Me, Thrill Me, Kiss Me, Kill Me," which became a top 20 hit.

1996: *Independence Day*

(L)

Stars: Will Smith, Bill Pullman, Jeff Goldblum, Mary McDonnell, Judd Hirsch

Director: Roland Emmerich

Music: David Arnold

Release date: July 3

Domestic grosses that year: \$306 million

Academy Awards: Two nods (sound, visual effects). One win (visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 73

Notes: With this film, Will Smith became the second Black actor (following Eddie Murphy) to be the top-billed star of a year's top-grossing box-office hit. The long-delayed sequel, *Independence Day: Resurgence*, wasn't nearly as successful. It was the No. 27 box-office hit of 2016.

1997: *Men in Black*

(L)

Stars: Tommy Lee Jones, Will Smith, Linda Fiorentino, Vincent D'Onofrio, Rip Torn

Director: Barry Sonnenfeld

Music: Danny Elfman

Release date: July 2

Domestic grosses that year: \$251 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (art direction, make-up, original musical or comedy score). One win (make-up).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (two weeks)

Notes: With this film coming on the heels of *Independence Day* as the year's top box-office hit, Smith became the first actor to star in the year's top box-office hit two years running. Smith's title track topped the Hot 100 Airplay chart for four weeks. Elfman's score soundtrack didn't chart.

1998: *Titanic*

(/)

Stars: Leonardo DiCaprio, Kate Winslet, Billy Zane, Gloria Stuart, Kathy Bates

Director: James Cameron

Music: James Horner

Release date: Dec. 19, 1997

Domestic grosses that year: \$488 million

Academy Awards: 14 nods. 11 wins including best picture, directing, original dramatic score and original song.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (16 consecutive weeks)

Notes: *Titanic* was the first film to gross more than \$400 million in a calendar year. In addition, it was the No. 7 box-office hit of 1997, its year of release.

year. In addition, it was the No. 1 box office hit of 1997, its year of release.

Celine Dion’s “My Heart Will Go On (Love Theme from Titanic)” topped the Hot 100 for two weeks and won Grammys for record and song of the year. *Titanic* is, to this day, one of only three films in Oscar history to receive 14 nominations — and also one of only three films to win 11 Oscars.

1999: *Star Wars: Episode I: The Phantom Menace* (L)

Stars: Liam Neeson, Ewan McGregor, Natalie Portman, Jake Lloyd, Samuel L. Jackson

Director: George Lucas

Music: John Williams

Release date: May 19

Domestic grosses that year: \$430 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (sound, sound effects editing, visual effects).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 3

Notes: This was the fourth film in the *Star Wars* franchise. All four wound up as the year’s top box-office hit.

2000: *Dr. Seuss’ How the Grinch Stole Christmas* (L)

Stars: Jim Carrey, Jeffrey Tambor, Christine Baranski, Bill Irwin, Molly

Stars: Daniel Radcliffe, Rupert Grint, Emma Watson, John Cleese, Robbie Coltrane

Director: Chris Columbus

Music: John Williams

Release date: Nov. 16

Domestic grosses that year: \$289 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (art direction, costume design, original score).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 48

Notes: This was the first film in the franchise. Only the first and last *Harry Potter* films wore the year-end box-office crown. No films in the franchise ever won an Oscar, despite 12 nominations over the years.

2002: *Spider-Man*

$$\emptyset$$

Stars: Tobey Maguire, Willem Dafoe, Kirsten Dunst, James Franco, Cliff Robertson

Director: Sam Raimi

Music: Danny Elfman

Release date: May 3

Domestic grosses that year: \$404 million

Academy Awards: Two nods (sound and visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 4

Notes: Chad Kroeger featuring Josey Scott's "Hero," from the pop soundtrack, reached No. 3 on the Hot 100. Elfman's score soundtrack didn't chart.

2003: *Finding Nemo*

(/)

Stars: (voice cast) Albert Brooks, Ellen DeGeneres, Alexander Gould, Willem Dafoe, Geoffrey Rush

Director: Andrew Stanton

Music: Thomas Newman

Release date: May 30

Domestic grosses that year: \$340 million

Academy Awards: Four nods including best original score. One win – animated feature film.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 156

Notes: The soundtrack, subtitled "Ocean Favorites," featured such water-themed classics as "Beyond the Sea," "Octopus' Garden," "Sea Cruise" and "Wipe Out." A few months after this film was released, DeGeneres launched her long-running daytime talk show, *The Ellen DeGeneres Show*. During the run of that show, she found time to make a sequel to *Finding Nemo*, which became the year-end box-office champ for 2016.

2004: *Shrek 2*

(/)

Stars: (voice cast) Mike Myers, Eddie Murphy, Cameron Diaz, Julie Andrews, Antonio Banderas

Director: Andrew Adamson, Kelly Asbury, Conrad Vernon

Music: Harry Gregson-Williams

Release date: May 19

Domestic grosses that year: \$441 million

Academy Awards: Two nods – animated feature film and best original song for Counting Crows’ “Accidentally in Love.”

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 8

Notes: This is the only film with three credited directors to wind up as the year’s top box-office hit. Coming on the heels of *Finding Nemo*, this marks the only time that animated films were the top box-office hits of back-to-back years. The first *Shrek* was the No. 2 box-office hit of 2001. Counting Crows’ “Accidentally in Love” became a top 40 hit on the Hot 100. The song had seven credited co-writers, all of whom were nominated. No other song in Oscar history has had so many nominated writers.

2005: *Star Wars: Episode III – Revenge of the Sith*

(L)

Stars: Ewan McGregor, Natalie Portman, Hayden Christensen, Ian McDiarmid, Samuel L. Jackson

Director: George Lucas

Music: John Williams

Release date: May 19

Domestic grosses that year: \$380 million

Academy Awards: One nod (makeup).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 6

Notes: This was the sixth film in the franchise; the fifth of them to wind up as the year’s top box-office hit. The streak was broken by *Star Wars: Episode 2 – Attack of the Clones*, which was the No. 2 box-office hit of 2002.

2006: *Pirates of the Caribbean: Dead Man’s Chest*

(/)



Pirates Of The Caribbean: Dead Man's Chest, 2006.
©WALT DISNEY CO. /COURTESY EVERETT COLLECTION

Stars: Johnny Depp, Orlando Bloom, Keira Knightley, Stellan Skarsgård, Bill Nighy

Director: Gore Verbinski

Music: Hans Zimmer

Release date: July 7

Domestic grosses that year: \$423 million

Academy Awards: Four nods. One win (visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 22

Notes: That Oscar for visual effects is the only one won by the entire franchise. This was the second film in the franchise, following *Pirates of the Caribbean: The Curse of the Black Pearl*, which was the No. 2 box-office hit of 2003.

2007: *Spider-Man 3*

(L)

Stars: Tobey Macguire, Kirsten Dunst, James Franco, Thomas Hayden Church, Topher Grace

Director: Sam Raimi

Music: Christopher Young

Release date: May 4

Domestic grosses that year: \$337 million

Academy Awards: Not a single nomination.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 33

Notes: This was the third film in the franchise; the second of them to wind up as the year's top box-office hit. *Spider-Man 2* was the No. 2 box-office hit of 2004.

2008: *The Dark Knight*

(L)

Stars: Christian Bale, Michael Caine, Heath Ledger, Gary Oldman, Aaron Eckhart

Director: Christopher Nolan

Music: Hans Zimmer and James Newton Howard

Release date: July 18

Domestic grosses that year: \$531 million

Academy Awards: Eight nods. Two wins – a posthumous best supporting actor award for Ledger and sound editing.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 20

Notes: *The Dark Knight* was the first film to gross more than \$500 million in a calendar year. This was the sixth film in the franchise; the fourth of them to wind up as the year's top-grossing hit. What became of the others? *Batman & Robin* was the No. 9 box-office hit of 1997. *Batman Begins* was the No. 7 box-office hit of 2005.

2009: *Transformers: Revenge of the Fallen*

(L)

Stars: Shia LeBeouf, Megan Fox, Josh Duhamel, Tyrese Gibson, John Turturro

Director: Michael Bay

Music: Steve Jablonsky

Release date: June 24

Domestic grosses that year: \$402 million

Academy Awards: One nod (sound mixing).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 7

Notes: This was the second film in this franchise, following *Transformers*, which was the No. 3 box-office hit of 2007. None of the films in the franchise has won an Oscar, despite a combined seven nods. The soundtrack included Linkin Park's "New Divide," a top 10 hit on the Hot 100, and two other rock hits that made the top 40 – The Fray's "Never Say Never" and Green Day's "21 Guns." Jablonsky's score soundtrack didn't chart.

2010: *Avatar*

(/)

Stars: Sam Worthington, Zoe Saldana, Stephen Lang, Michele Rodriguez, Sigourney Weaver

Director: James Cameron

Music: James Horner

Release date: Dec. 18, 2009

Domestic grosses that year: \$466 million

Academy Awards: Nine nods, including best picture, directing and original score. Three wins – art direction, cinematography and visual effects.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 31

Notes: In addition to its strong 2010 showing, *Avatar* was the No. 5 box-office hit of 2009, its year of release. This was the third time that both director Cameron and composer Horner had the year's top-grossing film. They collaborated on two of those films, *Titanic* and *Avatar*.

2011: *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part 2* (L)

Stars: Daniel Radcliffe, Rupert Grint, Emma Watson, Helena Bonham Carter, Robbie Coltrane

Director: David Yates

Music: Alexandre Desplat

Release date: July 15

Domestic grosses that year: \$381 million

Academy Awards: Three nods (art direction, makeup, visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 25

Notes: This was the eighth and final film in this franchise; the second of them to wind up as the year's top-grossing hit.

2012: *Mars's The Avengers* (L)

Stars: Robert Downey Jr., Chris Evans, Mark Ruffalo, Chris Hemsworth, Scarlett Johansson

Director: Josh Whedon

Music: Alan Silvestri

Release date: May 4

Domestic grosses that year: \$623 million

Academy Awards: One nod (visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 11

Notes: *The Avengers* was the first film to gross more than \$600 million in a calendar year. This was the first of three consecutive Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU) films to take the year-end box-office crown. The all-rock soundtrack featured tracks by Scott Weiland, Five Finger Death Punch, Bush and Evanescence, among others. Silvestri's score soundtrack reached No. 158.

2013: *Iron Man 3*

(D)

Stars: Robert Downey Jr., Gwyneth Paltrow, Don Cheadle, Guy Pearce, Rebecca Hall

Director: Shane Black

Music: Brian Tyler

Release date: May 3

Domestic grosses that year: \$409 million

Academy Awards: One nod (visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 16

Notes: With this film coming on the heels of *Marvel's The Avengers* as the year's top box-office hit, Downey became the second actor (following Will Smith) to star in the year's top box-office hit two years running. This was the third film in the franchise; the first of them to wind up as the year's top-grossing film. The first *Iron Man* was the No. 2 box-office hit of 2008. *Iron Man 2* was the No. 4 box-office hit of 2010. Tyler's score soundtrack reached No. 134, but a more pop-oriented collection featuring tracks by Walk the Moon, Imagine Dragons and

AWOL NATION reached No. 16

2014: *Guardians of the Galaxy* (D)



Guardians of the Galaxy, 2014.
WALT DISNEY STUDIOS MOTION PICTURES/COURTESY EVERETT COLLECTION

Stars: Chris Pratt, Zoe Saldana, Dave Bautista, Vin Diesel, Bradley Cooper

Director: James Gunn

Music: Tyler Bates

Release date: Aug. 1

Domestic grosses that year: \$333 million

Academy Awards: Two nods (makeup & hairstyling and visual effects).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (two weeks)

Notes: While Bates' score soundtrack stalled at No. 112, the pop soundtrack, *Guardians of the Galaxy: Awesome Mix Vol. 1*, topped the Billboard 200 for two

weeks. The album, which included such Nixon-era hits as Blue Swede's "Hooked on a Feeling" and The Raspberries' "Go All the Way," was the most entertaining compilation of '70s hits since Rhino's *Have a Nice Day* series.

2015: *Jurassic World*

(1)

Stars: Chris Pratt, Bryce Dallas Howard, Vincent D'Onofrio, Ty Simpkins, Nick Robinson

Director: Colin Trevorrow

Music: Michael Giacchino

Release date: June 12

Domestic grosses that year: \$652 million

Academy Awards: Not a single nomination.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 126

Notes: With this film coming on the heels of *Guardians of the Galaxy* as the year's top box-office hit, Pratt became the third actor (following Will Smith and Robert Downey Jr.) to star in the year's top box-office hit two years running. This film grossed more in a calendar year than any film up to that point. This was the fourth film in the franchise; the second of them to wind up as the year's box-office leader. *The Lost World: Jurassic Park* was the No. 2 box-office hit of 1997. *Jurassic Park III* was No. 7 for 2001. Bryce Dallas Howard, who played the female lead in this film, was maintaining a family tradition. Her father Ron Howard directed *Dr. Seuss' How the Grinch Stole Christmas*, the top-grossing film of the year for 2000.

2016: *Finding Dory* (L)

Stars: (voice cast) Ellen DeGeneres, Albert Brooks, Hayden Rolence, Ed O'Neill, Kaitlin Olson

Director: Andrew Stanton

Music: Thomas Newman

Release date: June 17

Domestic grosses that year: \$486 million

Academy Awards: Not a single nomination.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: Didn't chart

Notes: *Finding Nemo*/*Finding Dory* is the first, and so far only, animated franchise to yield the top box-office hit of two different years. Director Stanton and composer Newman also did the honors on *Finding Nemo*.

2017: *Star Wars: Episode VIII—The Last Jedi* (L)

Stars: Mark Hamill, Carrie Fisher, Adam Driver, Daisy Ridley, John Boyega

Director: Rian Johnson

Music: John Williams

Release date: Dec. 15

Domestic grosses that year: \$517 million

Academy Awards: Four nods including best original score.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 12

Notes: This is the eighth installment in the *Star Wars* franchise; the sixth of them to wind up as the year's top box-office hit. The No. 1 ranking of *The Last Jedi* gives both the franchise and composer Williams a remarkable 40-year span of year-end No. 1 rankings. The ageless Williams was 85 when this film was released.

2018: *Black Panther*

(/)

Stars: Chadwick Boseman, Michael B. Jordan, Lupita Nyong'o, Danai Gurira, Martin Freeman

Director: Ryan Coogler

Music: Ludwig Göransson

Release date: Feb. 16

Domestic grosses that year: \$700 million

Academy Awards: Seven nods, including best picture and best original song for "All the Stars." Three wins (costume design, original score, production design).

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 1 (three weeks)

Notes: *Black Panther* was the first film to gross \$700 million or more in a calendar year. It was also the first film directed by a Black director, and with a mostly Black cast, to emerge as the year's top box-office hit. It was the fourth Marvel Cinematic Universe film to take the year-end box-office crown. The soundtrack received a Grammy nomination for album of the year. Kendrick Lamar and SZA's "All the Stars" received Grammy nods for record and song of the year. An album featuring Göransson's score reached No. 64.

2019: *Avengers: Endgame*

(/)

Stars: Robert Downey Jr., Chris Evans, Mark Ruffalo, Chris Hemsworth, Scarlett Johansson

Director: Anthony Russo & Joseph Russo

Music: Alan Silvestri

Release date: April 26

Domestic grosses that year: \$858 million

Academy Awards: One nod – visual effects.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 88

Notes: *Avengers: Endgame* was the first film to gross more than \$800 million in a calendar year. It was the fourth film in the franchise; the second of them to take the year-end box-office crown. The other two came very close: *Avengers: Age of Ultron* was the No. 3 film of 2015. *Avengers: Infinity War* was No. 2 for 2018. *Avengers: Endgame* was the fifth Marvel Cinematic Universe film to take the year-end box-office crown.

2020: *Bad Boys for Life*

(/)

Stars: Will Smith, Martin Lawrence, Paola Núñez, Vanessa Hudgens, Alexander Ludwig

Director: Adil and Bialall (Adil El Arbi and Bilall Fallah)

Music: Lorne Balfe

Release date: Jan. 17

Domestic grosses that year: \$204 million

Academy Awards: Not a single nomination.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 63

Notes: This was the third film in the franchise, following *Bad Boys* (the No. 23 box-office hit of 1995) and *Bad Boys II* (the No. 10 box-office hit of 2003). None of the three films received an Oscar nomination. DJ Khaled served as executive producer of the soundtrack. Its lead single, “Ritmo (Bad Boys for Life)” by the Black Eyed Peas with J Balvin, reached No. 26 on the Hot 100.

2021: *Spider Man: No Way Home*

(/)

Stars: Tom Holland, Zendaya, Benedict Cumberbatch, Jacob Batalon, Jon Favreau

Director: Jon Watts

Music: Michael Giacchino

Release date: Dec. 17

Domestic grosses that year: \$573 million

Academy Awards: One nod – visual effects.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: Didn't chart.

Notes: Dec. 17 is the latest in the year that a film has been released and still

managed to emerge as the year's top box-office hit. This is the eighth film in the franchise; the third of them to wind up as the year's top box-office hit.

2022: *Top Gun: Maverick*

(L)

Stars: Tom Cruise, Miles Teller, Jennifer Connelly, Jon Hamm, Glen Powell

Director: Joseph Kosinski

Music: Harold Faltermeyer, Lady Gaga, Hans Zimmer

Release date: May 27

Domestic grosses that year: \$718 million

Academy Awards: 6 nods, including best picture and best original song for “Hold My Hand,” co-written by Lady Gaga and BloodPop. One win – best sound.

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: No. 17

Notes: This sequel arrived 36 years after the original *Top Gun*. The soundtrack produced two Hot 100 hits: Gaga's stately ballad “Hold My Hand” and OneRepublic's lighter and poppier “I Ain't Worried.” In addition to directing the film, Kosinski directed Gaga's music video for “Hold My Hand.”

2023: *Barbie*

(L)

Stars: Margot Robbie, Ryan Gosling, America Ferrera, Kate McKinnon

Director: Greta Gerwig

Music: Mark Ronson, Andrew Wyatt

Release date: July 21

Domestic grosses that year: \$636.2 million

Academy Awards: Eight nominations, including best picture. One win, best original song for Billie Eilish and Finneas (“What Was I Made For?”).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: No. 2

Notes: This was the first-year end No. 1 film to be directed by a woman (Gerwig). It was also co-written by a woman (also Gerwig) and co-produced by two women (Robbie and film executive Robbie Brenner). The doll upon which the movie was based was also invented by a woman (Ruth Handler, played by Rhea Perlman in the movie) way back in 1959.

2024: *Inside Out 2*

(/)

Voice cast: Amy Poehler, Maya Hawke, Liza Lapira, Tony Hale, Lewis Black

Director: Kelsey Mann

Music: Andrea Datzman

Release date: June 14

Domestic grosses that year: \$653 million

Academy Awards: One nod (animated feature film).

Soundtrack’s Billboard 200 peak: Didn’t chart.

Notes: Datzman made history as the first woman to score a Pixar film and the first woman to score a film that became the year-end No. 1. (Lady Gaga was among those who worked on the music for *Top Gun: Maverick*.) Michael Giacchino scored the first *Inside Out* film in 2015.

2025: *A Minecraft Movie*

(L)

Stars: Jason Momoa, Jack Black, Emma Myers, Danielle Brooks, Sebastian Hansen, Jennifer Coolidge

Director: Jared Hess

Music: Mark Mothersbaugh

Release date: April 4

Domestic grosses that year: \$423.9 million

Academy Awards: to be determined

Soundtrack's Billboard 200 peak: Didn't chart

Notes: *A Minecraft Movie* outpaced *Lilo and Stitch*, the year's runner-up in terms of domestic grosses by a mere \$170K. Theaters spend more than that on popcorn butter. Mothersbaugh rose to prominence in the late 1970s as co-founder, lead vocalist and keyboardist of Devo, whose "Whip It" cracked the top 15 on the Billboard Hot 100 in 1980. He broke into film music in 1987 and has since scored dozens of films. *A Minecraft Movie* sequel is in the works for 2027.

A track from the soundtrack, Jack Black's "Steve's Lava Chicken," made the Billboard Hot 100 dated May 3, 2025 – and set a new record as the shortest song ever to make the chart. The song runs just 34 seconds, three seconds shorter than the previous record-holder as the shortest Hot 100 hit: Kid Cudi's "Beautiful Trip," which runs 37 seconds. **[Full details here](https://www.billboard.com/lists/jack-black-minecraft-song-steves-lava-chicken-hot-100-record/)**
[\(https://www.billboard.com/lists/jack-black-minecraft-song-steves-lava-chicken-hot-100-record/\)](https://www.billboard.com/lists/jack-black-minecraft-song-steves-lava-chicken-hot-100-record/).